

her intimidating power game. “She’s incorporated drop shots, slices, she comes to the net more, she has more variety,” noted seven-time French Open champion Chris Evert. “She also has a better attitude when she’s in trouble,” said Mary Joe Fernandez, a *TNT* analyst.

Sabalenka, who had broken Swiatek’s serve just 10 times in their 12 previous matches, easily broke the Pole three straight times with a barrage of winners to surge ahead 4-1. Swiatek fought back with three service breaks to force a tie-break only to have Sabalenka crush her 7-1.

Flattening out her forehand from an average of 3,073 rpm in the first set to 2,360 in the second set and returning Sabalenka’s big serves aggressively, Swiatek captured the second set 6-4. First-strike tennis paid off handsomely.

Alas, Swiatek couldn’t slug it out anymore against a natural slugger during the deciding set. In the most dominating set of the year between elite players, Sabalenka overwhelmed and dethroned Swiatek 6-0, winning 24 of 30 points. “To win the set 6-0 against Iga on clay is something out of my mind,” admitted Sabalenka, who ended Swiatek’s 26-match winning streak at Roland-Garros and became the first player to defeat her twice on clay.

Stephens assessed the impressive triumph in more personal terms. “Sabalenka is a very vengeful person. She’s going for blood, as she said against Zheng.”

Keys, the surprise Australian Open champion, gave Gauff her toughest challenge before the final. Despite 41 unforced errors versus just 15 winners, Gauff prevailed 6-7 (6), 6-4, 6-1 by ‘winning ugly’, something her former coach Brad Gilbert used to take pride in. Her relentless determination and running game — a vacuum cleaner defence — induced many of Keys’ 60 unforced errors.

“It’s just I have always had that in me, and not just in tennis but in everything. I’m a very competitive person,” explained Gauff. “My philosophy is if I can just leave it all out there, then the loss will hurt a lot less than regrets of maybe not giving

it your all.” Led by Gauff, Keys, and Frances Tiafoe in singles, an African American made the quarterfinals (or better) in all five of the professional events—men’s singles, women’s singles, men’s doubles, women’s doubles and mixed doubles—at a single Grand Slam tournament for the first time in tennis history.

Meanwhile, if you hadn’t heard of Lois Boisson (**below**) before the French Open, you weren’t the only one. A wild card ranked a lowly No. 361, Boisson made her Tour-level debut at Rouen in May and her Grand Slam debut in Paris. The 22-year-old Frenchwoman made the most of it by streaking all the way to the semifinals.

Her fairytale fortnight started in the first round when she upset 24th-seeded Belgian veteran Elise Mertens 6-4, 4-6, 6-3. Parlaying a devastating topspin forehand, blazing speed, deft volleys, and exceptional touch shots to offset a weak backhand, she then shocked a nervous No. 3 seed Jessica Pegula 3-6, 6-4, 6-4 and 18-year-old sensation and No. 6 Mirra Andreeva 7-6 (6), 6-3. The Russian became so frustrated at 3-all from the raucous hometown fans that she whacked a ball into the crowd, which rained her with a chorus of boos.

Boisson, a hidden talent with a style reminiscent of Samantha Stosur, the former US Open winner and French Open runner-up, was sidelined for nine months with a torn ACL. She returned to competition in April. Fearless in the big moments, the muscular, 5’9” Boisson became just the third woman — after teen phenoms Jennifer Capriati and Monica Seles — to make the semifinals in her debut Major.

“I think every kid who plays tennis has the dream to win a Slam,” said Boisson. “More for French players to win Roland-Garros, for sure. So, yeah, it’s a dream. For sure, I will go for the dream, because my dream is to win it, not to be in the semifinal.”

Gauff ended her Cinderella story with an emphatic 6-1, 6-2 victory over the 500-1 pre-tournament long shot. Like a savvy veteran, she attacked Boisson’s vulnerable backhand — an

erratic two-hander and a soft slice one-hander — and blocked out the stentorian crowd. Gauff copied a trick Djokovic used when he played crowd favourites. “Actually, when you guys were chanting her name, I was saying to myself my name, just to psych myself out.”

As Gauff has done ever since she burst on the scene as a precocious 15-year-old upsetting Venus Williams at Wimbledon to make the round of 16 in her Grand Slam main draw debut, she set more ‘youngest records’ at Roland-Garros.

Gauff became the youngest to win Major women’s titles on multiple surfaces since Maria Sharapova at Wimbledon in 2004 and the US Open in 2006 as well as the youngest American to win the singles title at Roland-Garros since Serena Williams in 2002.

Evert, a teen queen who won 18 singles Majors during her 19-year career, believes ‘Mrs Maturity’, as Tiafoe calls her, “will win 10, 12, 14 Majors. She’s so much more mature than a 21-year-old. She’s more like 25, 26.”



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